

CAPYBARA

The largest rodent, the capybara, is one of four species in the Caviidae subfamily Hydrochoerinae. Capybaras generally breed once a year; the offspring are born at the end of the wet season, when the grass is most nutritious. They may live up to six years.



CAPYBARA
Hydrochoeris hydrochaeris

As big as a pig, this is the world's largest rodent. It lives a semi-aquatic life in the swamps of S. America.

1–1.3 m
3¼–4¼ ft

HUTIAS, SPINY RATS, AND COYPU

A Central and South American family, the Echimyidae comprises 99 species that live in a variety of habitats, and includes tree-dwelling and burrowing spiny rats, and the semi-aquatic coypu. Although they vary in size, fur type, and dentition as well as diet, phylogenetic and molecular analyses suggest they belong in the same group.

16–30 cm
6½–12 in



SPINY RAT
Proechimys sp.

These rodents have a spiny protective coat. This feature has evolved in parallel to the spiny mice of Africa.

30–43 cm
12–17 in



DESMAREST'S CUBAN HUTIA
Capromys pilorides

This hutia is common in Cuba. Other surviving hutia species face extinction because of a loss of their habitat and hunting.

47–58 cm
18½–23 in



COYPU
Myocastor coypus

This animal has distinctively shaggy fur and huge orange front teeth. It also has webbed hind feet for swimming and a thick, scaly tail.

PACAS

This family includes two species of nocturnal rodent from Central and South America. The Cuniculidae resemble small pigs as they root about on the forest floor for fruits, seeds, and roots.

50–75 cm
20–30 in



LOWLAND PACA
Cuniculus paca

Mainly a forest inhabitant, this rodent lives in the northern part of S. America, from Mexico to Paraguay.

DEGUS, ROCK RATS, AND RELATIVES

The molar teeth of these small, silky furred rats form a figure-of-eight shape when worn, giving them their Latin name. The Octodontidae are widespread in the southern part of South America.

16–22 cm
6½–9 in



DEGU
Octodon degus

This species is found on the western slopes of the Andes in Chile. Its tail breaks off easily if caught by a predator.

AGOUTIS

Active during the day, these long-legged, running rodents of the family Dasyproctidae are very shy. They breed all year round but have only two young at a time, which can run within an hour of birth.

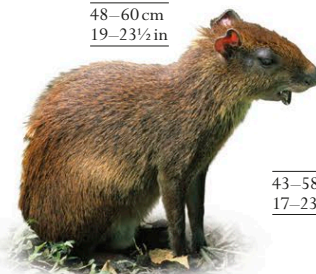
RED-RUMPED AGOUTI
Dasyprocta leporina

Found in forested areas of northeastern S. America and the Lesser Antilles, this species can be identified by its light orange rump.



48–60 cm
19–23½ in

48–60 cm
19–23½ in



CENTRAL AMERICAN AGOUTI
Dasyprocta punctata

With a range that extends from Mexico south to Argentina, this agouti mainly feeds on fruits, but may also eat crabs. Pairs are thought to stay together for life.

AZARA'S AGOUTI
Dasyprocta azarae

An inhabitant of the forests of S. Brazil, Paraguay, and N. Argentina, this agouti barks when alarmed. It eats a variety of seeds and fruits.

